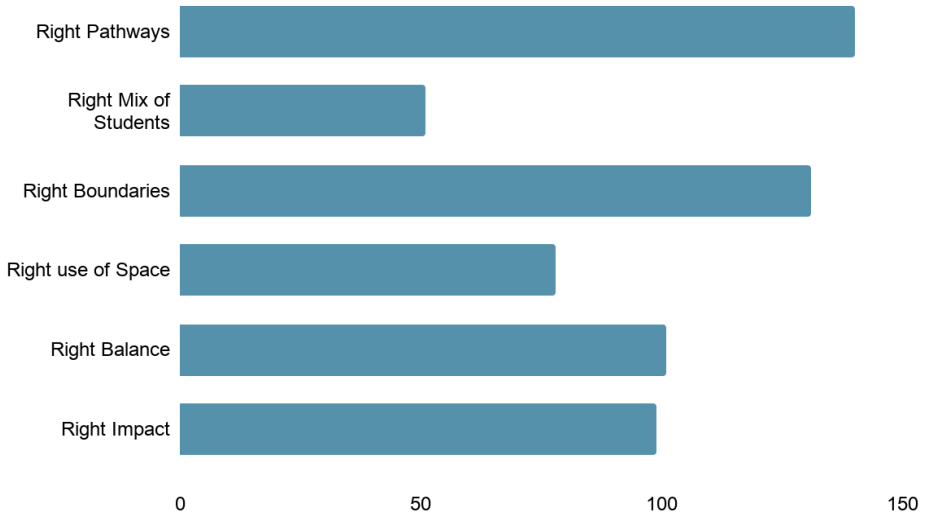
**Board Engagement Summary at Ida B. Wells**
**April 22, 2026**

Between 106-205 respondents answered each Slido question during the engagement session held at Ida B. Wells on April 22. While over 40 school communities were represented, Rieke Elementary, Bridlemile Elementary, and Chief Joseph Elementary were the most widely represented schools at this engagement session, and approximately 90% of participants were part of a K-5 school community. 3% of participants identified as African American/Black, 1% as American Indian/Alaska Native, 5% identified as Asian, 3% as Hispanic/Latino/Latinx, 1% as Middle Eastern/North African, 80% identified as white, 11% identified as multiracial, and 8% declined to answer this question.Nearly half of families in attendance have students who are identified as talented and gifted. Only 6% of families responding had experienced a boundary change in the last five years.

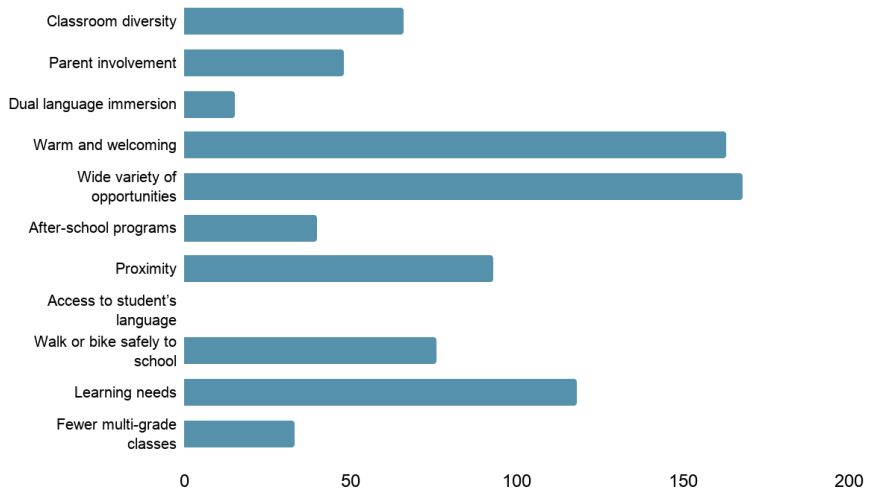
Of the six factors in the PPS student assignment policy, respondents prioritized feeder pattern that allows as many students as possible to continue together from one school level to the next, compact boundaries that promote safer routes to schools and a sense of community as well as recognize and address natural and human-made barriers, and program and enrollment stability in the surrounding schools over other factors.See Chart 1 for a breakdown of responses to this question.

**Chart 1:**
*Responses to the question, "Our Portland Public Schools Student Assignment Policy asks us to consider the following six factors. Please select the three most important factors to consider during program and enrollment balancing across our system." (200 responses)*



When asked to rank four factors that make a positive school environment, respondents identified a warm and welcoming school environment, a wide variety of learning opportunities, access to services that meet every student's learning need, and ability of children who live close together to attend the same school as the highest priorities. See Chart 2 for a breakdown of responses to this question.

**Chart 2:**
*Responses to the question, "select the top four factors that you think make a positive school environment" (205 responses)*




111 respondents answered the question, "What has helped you/your student feel connected as they move from one school to the next?" Families shared that support systems in schools are built from a deep sense of community and continuity, where students thrive through long-term relationships with neighbors, peers, and school staff. Walkability to school, playground visits, and guided tours help reduce transition anxiety and create a feeling of physical safety. Additionally, these families value proactive transparency and engagement, specifically through dedicated staff like climate specialists, high parent involvement in PTA-led events, and clear communication from school leadership.

Additionally, 106 families shared responses to the question, In the past five years, has your family experienced a school transition that you initiated? Families that chose to transition school environments sought out specialized environments that offer academic rigor for gifted students or specific support for neurodivergent learners that neighborhood schools lacked. Other transitions were driven by

environmental concerns, including high class sizes, unsafe school climates, and funding disparities that lead parents to consider private alternatives.

Overall, feedback from this listening session emphasized that neighborhood schools provide essential social threads that connect families and foster student safety. Many parents argue that closing high-achieving schools like Rieke or unique locations like Skyline would ignore the non-monetary value of community stability and localized support systems. There is significant concern regarding the potential of split-feeder patterns, where students are separated from their peer groups during critical developmental transitions into middle school. Furthermore, families of children in specialized focus programs or K-8 models emphasize that these environments are often the only reason they remain in the public school system rather than opting for private education.